The Unsent Letter

I found this folded letter inside the cedar chest of the Sanctuary, beneath the oldest charts. An ancient Oracle wrote it to the Mirror Speaker of Tower III, but never sent it. The words were set down in mirror script, just as the glass sees them. Held before a mirror, the letters turn and become easy to read.

To the Mirror Speaker of the third tower,

Forgive me. I closed my door to you when your crossed the plateau to see me, and I have been sorry every night since.

Now hear what only we two know. Your mirror did not fall. We broke it together into nine pieces, and hid each piece in your theatre. While the nine are apart, no one can turn the Astrolabe alone: not the Order, not you, not I.

And beware the Ashes. They were old before the Order was born. They keep a fire older than our first star, and they want what the Astrolabe opens. They will come to you smiling.

The first piece sleeps behind a thousand faces. Only the one who sees what is not equal will find it.

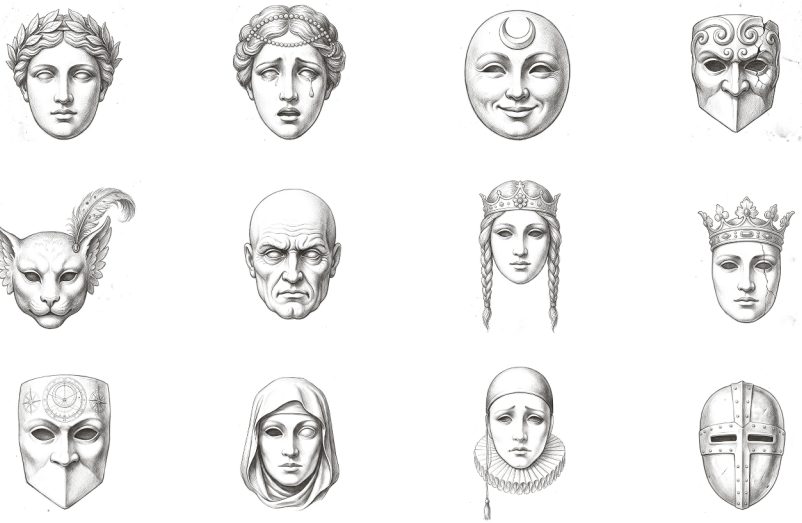
The Oracle

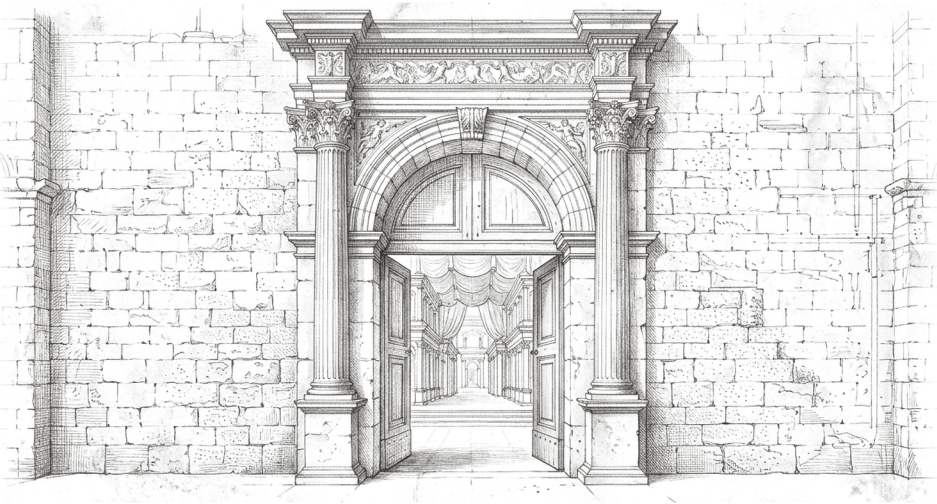
From this high pass, Tower III rises before me: a colossal amphitheatre carved into the mountain rim, its grand stage facing the abyss. The letter in the cedar chest changes everything. The Great Mirror was not destroyed by chance, but broken by design—divided into nine fragments and hidden across the nine halls of the theatre to safeguard the Astrolabe from the Ashes. With this looking glass and my journal in hand, I step toward the Gate of a Thousand Masks. The Stage Path has begun.

The Gate of a Thousand Masks

Before me, the threshold of Tower III is sealed by a colossal wall of carved visors. In this theatre of stone, twelve ancient masks guard the dark passage. Some are cast in perfect symmetry, true to the sacred glass; others hide subtle flaws in their features, carved to deceive the unwary.

Study each face carefully in this codex. When the lanterns flicker upon the gate, trust only what is reflected true: the theatre watches your gaze.

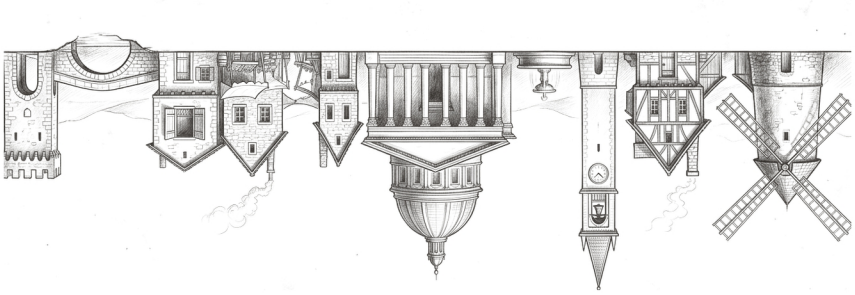


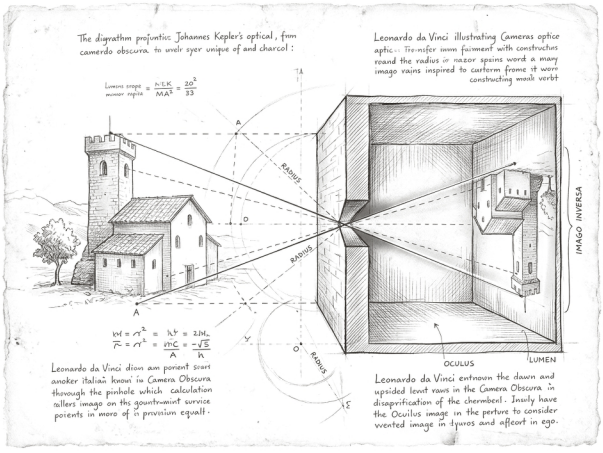


The Camera Obscura

Beyond the gate of masks, I enter a dark chamber pierced by a single aperture. Through this pinhole, sunlight projects the living city of Tower III onto the stone wall, cast upside down by the geometry of light. Here in this codex, I have drawn the streets as they stood the day before the raiders struck.

Keep this page beside you. In the chamber ahead, four things in the city have changed since this sketch was made. Find each difference—and watch where smoke rises, for the raiders leave their trace in fire.





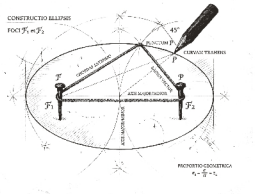
The Three Hearths

In this codex, two hearths send white smoke into the sky: the mill and the market lodge. If the chamber ahead reveals a third chimney breathing fire, seek the narrow door beneath it. The raiders kindle hearths where none should burn.

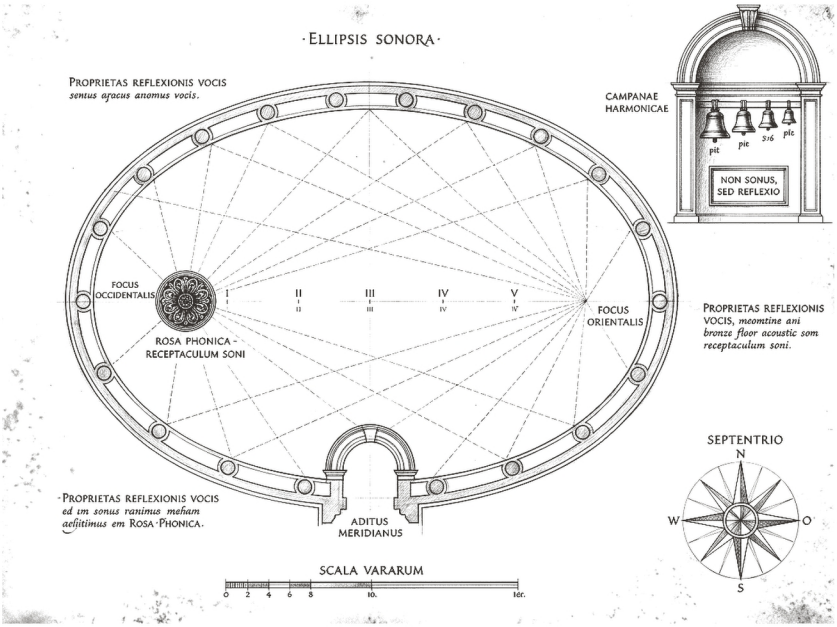
The seal of this room. Scan it with your camera when the door asks for it.

The Whispering Gallery

Beneath the narrow house, past the hearth where the raiders lit their fire, a stair leads to a silent hall with no corners. The Order laid it out using Kepler's planetary orbits: two pins in the stone, a string of ten varas, and a taut pencil. A whisper at one pin travels the curved wall to the other, clear as a bell. Nowhere else.



The pins are gone, but the string never stretched. Find where they stood along the floor: five varas measured from the northern curve to the central axis marks the listening rose. The raiders whisper at the eastern pin: stand at the western one, and listen.



The Secret of the Niche

The stone vault does not repeat a song: it mirrors it. When the five bronze bells of the niche ring across the stones, answer them not as they sounded, but from the last chime to the first.

« Non sonus, sed reflexio. »

The Alpine Memories

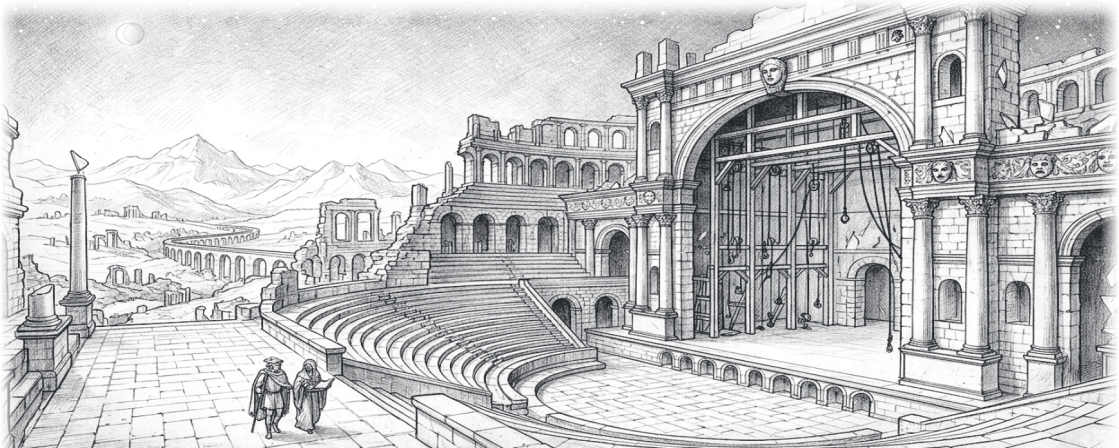
Aurelia: When the cold wind rises, the mist clears from the northern peaks. I still remember the high stone steps of Tower I, the great brass dome turning in absolute silence, and the long winter nights we spent reading the stars together beside the fire.

Tower I: The Alpine Observatory. The telescope slit faced Polaris through the longest winter nights.

Leontopodium nivale
High crags · alt. 2400 varas

Aurelia: This little white flower blooms in the deep rock fissures near the summit. Its petals are as soft as wool, shielding the tiny seed from the alpine frost. We pressed one into the pages of our Astrolabe log on the twenty-third day of September. If you climb high enough, the snow remembers every single footstep.

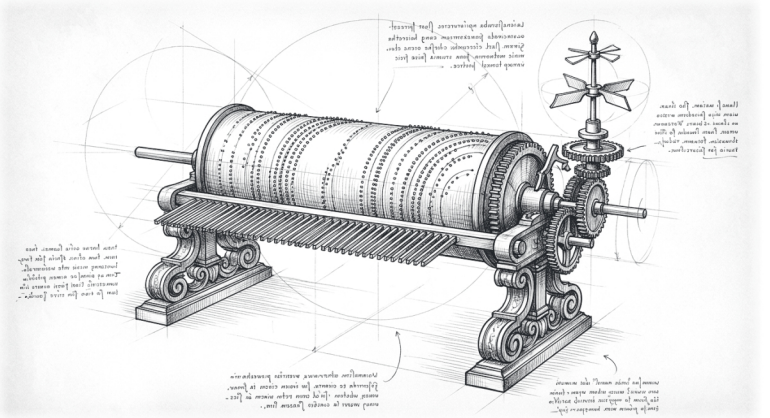
Hermes: She is beginning to remember the way back. The road to the peaks is still open.



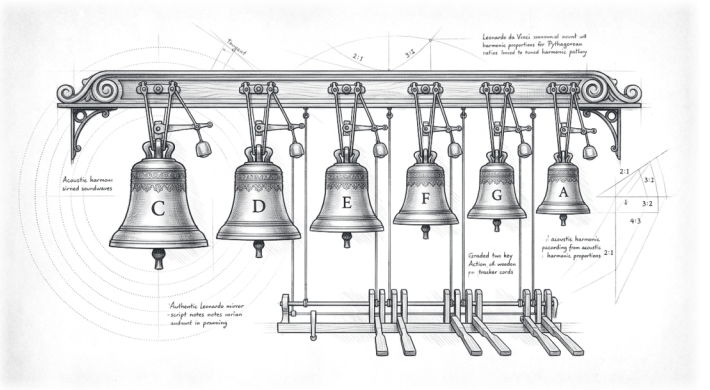
The Automaton Orchestra

In the silent music chamber of Tower III, three clockwork musicians sit motionless upon the stage. Carved from aged pearwood and polished brass, their hands rest frozen over lute, pipe, and dulcimer, waiting for the gears to turn once more. Beneath the cedar floorboards, a great bronze cylinder bristling with iron pins holds their forgotten melodies.

Study the measures upon the drum. The song that opens the gate is the reflection of the melody: read each pitch from the opposite rim of the cylinder, from the last measure to the first.



Six bronze bells hang beneath the soundboard, tuned to the natural hexachord. To open the door of the Orchestra, play the reflection of the melody upon the bells.



The tuning of the six bells: C · D · E · F · G · A. The last note struck is the first to unlock.

The Fly Tower

High in the timber rafters above the stage hangs the vast rigging of the fly tower. Hand-hewn pulleys of seasoned boxwood guide the oiled hemp cords that once balanced the painted heavens, the moving clouds, and the heavy scenic machinery of Tower III.

The raiders severed the rigging lines to drop the iron proscenium curtain across the stage. Merely hauling on the remaining cords will snap the hemp: Serlio and Sabbatini engineered a dual balance lock to prevent catastrophic collapse.

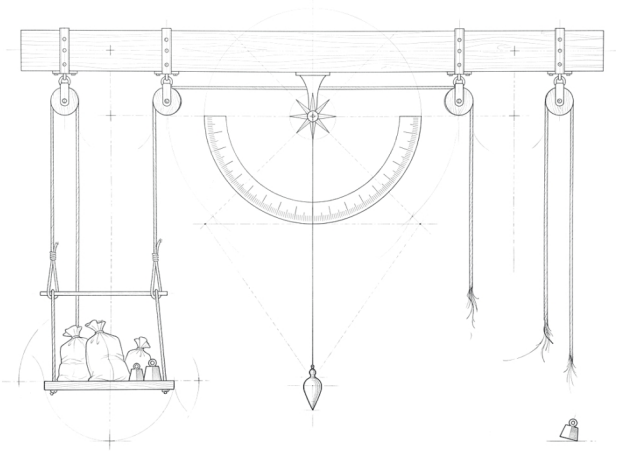


Plate XII - Unified theatrical fly tower rigging (Tower III). Serlio & Sabbatini mechanical system.

I. The Clinometer & Safety Brake
The semicircular clinometer suspended from the tie-beam measures the true horizontal level of the curtain. Settle the plumb-bob exactly upon thirty-eight degrees on the bronze arc: only at this equilibrium does the internal ratchet pawl disengage from the drum, releasing the safety brake.

II. The West Counterweight Cradle
The raiders slashed the eastern lines in haste, locking the proscenium in darkness. Once the safety brake is disengaged, distribute the sandbags and iron ingots upon the west cradle. When the cradle counterweight equals the mass of the curtain, the proscenium raises smoothly.

Field note: If the plumb-line drifts even two degrees from thirty-eight, the iron teeth bite and lock the track. Set the balance first; weigh the cradle second.

The Ashes Before Christ

The letters carved upon their iron saddles do not name common desert raiders. 'BC' is neither a calendar year nor a province: it stands for Before Christ. They are a brotherhood far older than our Order, custodians of a primordial flame that was tended in these lands long before our first observatory was raised.

They believe the stars only reflect what the earth first burned. Their masked leader signs each decree with a seal of soot: a circle cut in two by an iron stroke, the mark of the first flame. They seek the Fourth Chamber, but they do not destroy: they watch, and they leave tokens for the one who walks behind them.

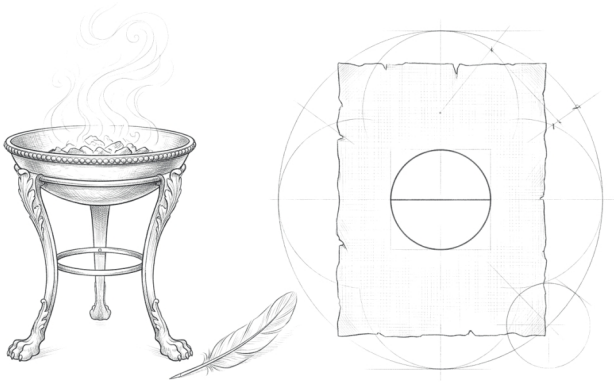


Plate XIII - The bronze tripod brazier and the ancient papyrus. The seal of ash inverts the symbol of the Order.

Hermes found their camp empty at dawn. In the cold embers lay a single golden feather, untouched by the smoke. Weighted beneath an iron rivet rested a folded slip of parchment:

> «Do not mistake our fire for pity, traveler. We kindle the braziers ahead not to guide you, but to test if you can endure our smoke. The dark would have taken you before thirty paces. Gather the nine shards of the living glass: the fourth door yields to no one but the key.»

Hermes' note: A harsh warning, yet he lit every stair ahead of us. Pope-E knew Silvia was following our steps. Why does our pursuer call her the key?

The Shadow Theatre

Behind the heavy proscenium curtain lies an intimate theatre of light and shade. Three Venetian oil lamps hang suspended from an iron rail above the stage, casting the sharp profiles of articulated brass puppets across the taut linen screen. Here, the early masters practiced the art of silhouettes to convey silent ciphers.

When the raiders fled through this hall, they left the silhouettes scattered across the boards. To awaken the screen, arrange the brass figures along the beam between the flames. When the shadow of the tower and the crescent align, hold this page against a lantern: the light passing through both faces will bring the secret cipher into focus.

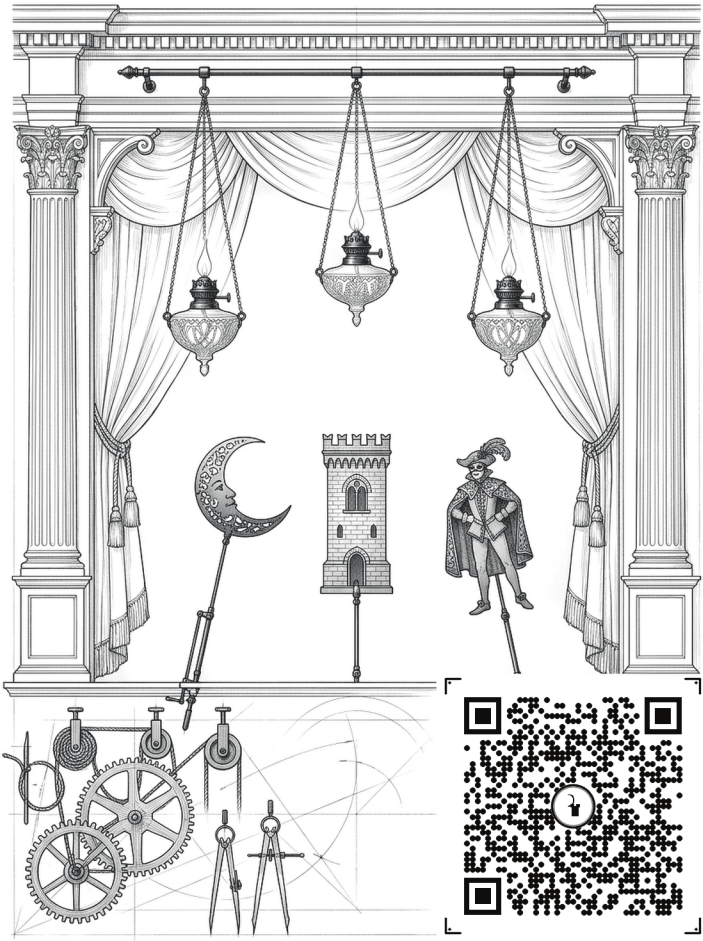
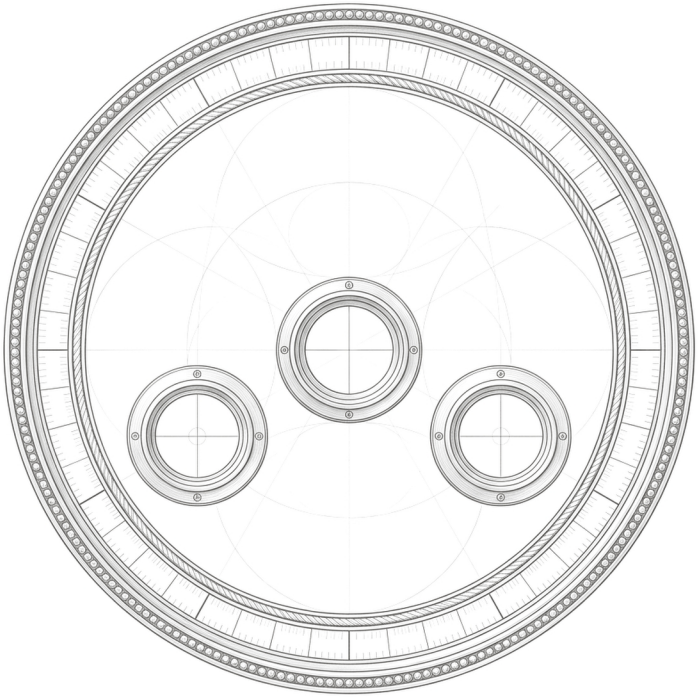


Plate XIV – Apparato per il Teatro delle Ombre (Tower III). Articulated brass silhouettes and room seal.

The Disc and the Vow

In the autumn of 1970, before our order parted ways, we cast this disc of bronze to seal a solemn vow. Its twenty-four engraved spokes divide the hours of the night and the zodiac. Three small apertures were pierced at the exact angles where the stage lamps burn. Held up to a candle, the light shining through both faces reveals the secret word of our covenant.

A.



Instructions for the Flame

1. In a darkened room, place a single lit candle or light behind this page.

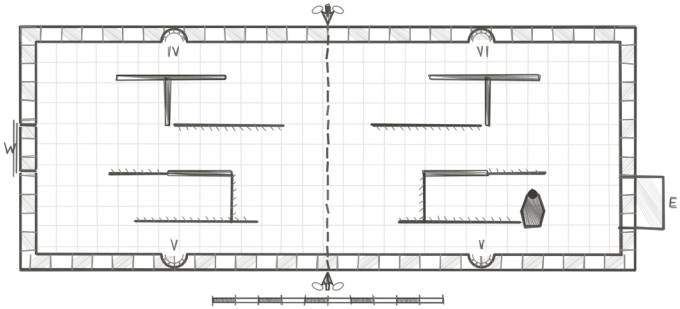
2. Hold Sheet 23 upright between your eyes and the flame, with this disc facing you.

3. Look through the three pierced apertures: the light shining from behind will align with the stage lamps of the front face, revealing the secret letters of our vow.

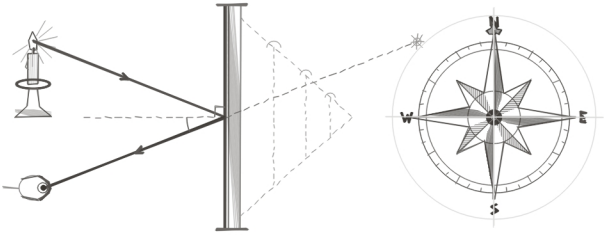
The Hall of Mirrors

A labyrinth of silvered glass fills the inner gallery. Every wall is an optical mirror, and every passage reflects a corridor that does not exist.

The compass does not turn inside the glass gallery; the mirrors rotate the light, not the earth. Count twenty Venetian paces from the Western gate: at each mirrored alcove, reject the path that duplicates your candle. Follow only the corridor where your shadow walks ahead of you.



Scala di Venti Passi Veneziani



The Rule of the Twenty Paces

Do not let the glass deceive your stride. Fold Sheet 24 along the central silver axis: the false reflections cancel against stone masonry, revealing the only unmirrored route through the twenty paces to the inner chamber.

"Never trust the corridor that reflects your own eyes; the true path reflects only the lanterns behind you."

Twenty paces from gate to sanctum: where the glass lies, the compass remembers.

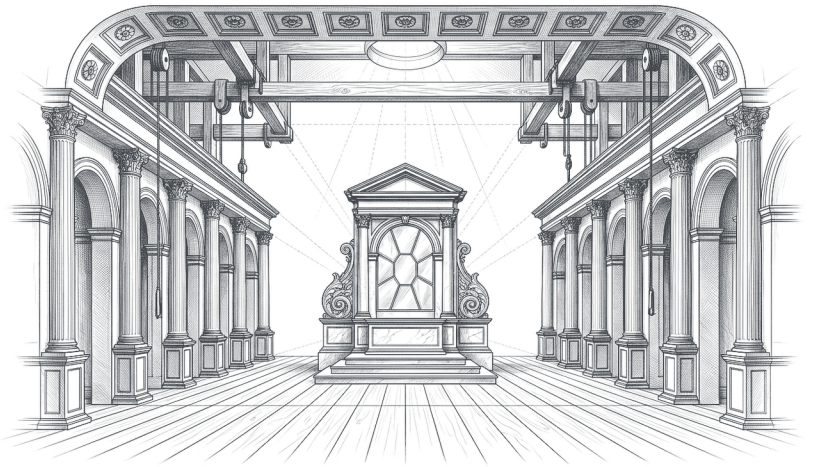
The Doctrine of the Mirror Speaker

The mirror creates no light of its own; it only returns what you bring to it. If you walk with hurried steps, you will meet only your own haste upon the glass.

The nine pieces were not broken in anger, but in kindness. A truth shared between nine rooms cannot be stolen by one pair of hands. Stand still before the threshold; when you stop reaching, the glass clears.

Bring the fragments together when the night is quiet. What you see in the completed glass is the place where our journey was always meant to end.

- The Mirror Speaker



Aurelia (1970)
Pope-E burned the ropes above the stage and filled the lower halls with smoke, but he could not cross this threshold. Some places cannot be taken by fire. They are built of quiet patience, not walls you can break. There was no gold for him to plunder here, only mirrors that turn a stranger back upon himself. By the time the Ashes reach this room, our steps will already be high in the mountains.

Hermes (1998)
Silvia, when you bring the nine pieces of glass to the stage altar, remember what the Mirror Speaker wrote. Do not look for your own face in the mirror.

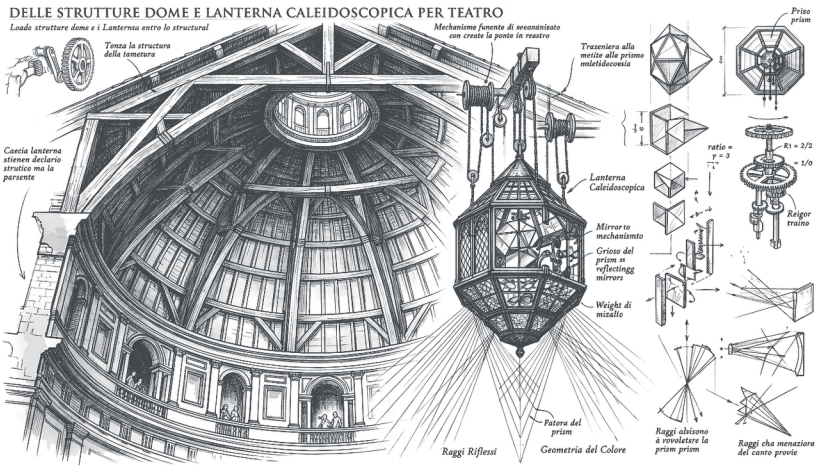
The last piece does not show who holds it. When the lantern overhead shines through the prisms, the glass turns into an open window-revealing the great theater in the city where we will finally meet.

You already hold seven pieces. Only the light and the stage remain.

The Kaleidoscope Lantern

Thirty paces above the empty stage, the great dome narrows to its zenith. Suspended in the gloom hangs the octagonal lantern-an intricate crown of brass, counterweights, and polished quartz prisms. From this dizzying height, the proscenium below is but a quiet shadow in the dust, waiting for the first beam of light.

Through the eight sides of the drum, morning sun and candle glow are divided into pure geometric harmonies. Turn the outer brass ring until the refracted rays converge upon the passage dial; the spectrum marks the pathway to the high terrace.



Aurelia (1970)

When Pope-E set fire to the rigging below, the smoke rose thick into the vault, but the fire could not reach these heights. I climbed the iron rungs to the lantern drum while the bells were still sounding. I turned the prism vernier to the northern angle, casting a beam of amber light through the high archway to guide our companions across the terrace. Then I dropped the iron pin into the gear train so no stranger could turn the glass. The lantern held its secret while the theatre burned.

Hermes (1998)

Silvia, the iron pin was still resting in the teeth of the drum when I arrived, covered in twenty-eight years of mountain dust. The quartz prisms are undamaged. When you solve the alignment in the lantern, the lock will release and the door to the northern terrace will swing open.

Beyond this dome lies the open sky. We are one step from the final stage.

The Terrace Under the Stars

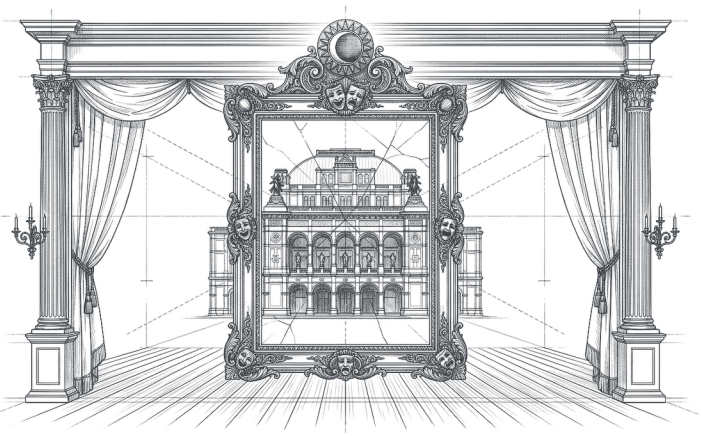
"Look down at the gorge, Hermes. The torches are climbing
toward the ice with our Astrolabe. Sleep well tonight.
At the first light of dawn, the mountain is ours."

- Aurelia

The Stage of the Mirror Speaker

The centre of the stage is cleared. In the grand Venetian frame, eight fragments of mirror already rest. When the ninth piece is laid into the glass, the cracks heal and the true reflection awakens.

Gather the marks from the margins of Sheets 19 to 26. In order, they reveal the words of the ceremony. Look deep into the restored glass: it does not reflect this underground hall, but a great palace of music five hundred leagues to the north. Count the five arches of its loggia; let the restored reflection speak its name when the ninth piece is laid in the frame.

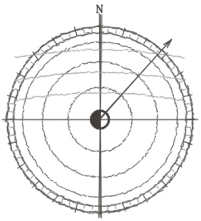


The Liturgy of the Mirror Speaker

"You did not seek an echo, Silvia; you sought an awakening. The nine shards were scattered through the gloom so that only hands that honour symmetry could heal what fire tried to sever. Now look deep into the glass: across five hundred leagues of mountain and river, the grand hall of the imperial capital awaits, where the stone dances and the strings are tuned to your arrival. Walk into the snow with an untroubled heart. The mirror never forgets what it has once reflected."

– The Mirror Speaker

The Celestial Meridian of the 48th Parallel



Meridian Dial · 48° 12′ N

Astrometric Sighting · Imperial Basin

Zenith Latitude: 48° 12′ 12″ N · Imperial Meridian: 16° 22′ 08″ E

True Bearing: 354° North through the Alpine Pass · Elevation: 171 m

Hermes: The line is true. From the proscenium of Tower III, the sighting line passes directly over the high shoulder of Tower I and descends into the imperial valley. The raiders flee along our exact meridian. At first light, we pack the instruments and ride toward the snow.

H. & A.

Back to the Peaks

The Stage Path is finished. The restored glass has spoken, casting its true reflection northward across five hundred leagues to the imperial palace of music. Yet our journey cannot rest while the Astrolabe remains lost to the ashes.

At first light we pack the sighting instruments, strap the brass cases to the mules, and step out from the underground proscenium into the sharp alpine dawn. Aurelia has released the white dove toward the crags of Tower I to announce our ascent. Ahead lies the Chasm Pass, where the ancient road climbs to the secret convergence of the Three Towers.

TOWER II · SANDSTONE SANCTUARY
The Desert Path · Solar Meridian

TOWER III · THE STAGE TOWER
Departure Bearing: 354° North

Bearings: 354° North from Tower III through the Chasm Pass toward Tower I and the Vault. – H. & A.